Coming Home

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Teen And Up Audiences

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Coming Home

by Paganaidd

Summary

Lenio was too stars-damned old to be woken by middle-of-the-night crises. But apparently the universe did not receive the memo.

No one had entertained the possibility of the Princess's survival.

Akrash wanted to caution the Queen again that this might not be C'yara. Except for the transformation as Lyra had claimed her as her daughter. By some strange alchemy, the hurricane of teeth and claws collapsed into a child.

Hidden scenes from Halfmoon, right after Chapter 4 of Defiance by TheNotebookWizard

Notes

Read after Defiance Chapter 4.

Chapter 1: Summons

Chapter Summary

> Catra woke, disoriented and in pain, her adrenaline in overdrive. Of course she had run amok through the castle. She was a walking booby trap no-one had bothered to defuse.
>
> It'd been a while since Lenio had to explain to an enemy combatant that he did not want to vivisect them.

Halfmoon Infirmary
Halfmoon Castle

Two days after Catra's abduction

Queen Lyra would let no one else carry the girl to the infirmary. Only Akrash and Cloudfoot followed her. Once she got there, the medical staff scurried out of her way, so she put the girl in the first clean patient room.

"Akrash?" Lyra put her hand on the girl's head and stroked her ears as she spoke. The child did not even move. "I need you to stay with her." Lyra swallowed. "I won't have this bungled again." The Queen's eyes were red, but no tears fell. "I'll be back soon."

"Majesty? Where are you going?" Cloudfoot asked.

"I'm going to see if I can get Lenio to look after her."

Akrash stilled.

Lenio.

Still alive? He hadn't dreamed…

When Akrash first arrived in Halfmoon, he'd seen that Lenio no longer held his office and he didn't look further. He'd never

wanted to confirm his old mentor's death. Would not have been able to hold himself together if he'd seen a death certificate.

"Do not let anyone else in here. I won't have my daughter upset again."

Akrash wanted to caution the Queen again that this might not be C'yara. Except for the transformation on the girl's face as Lyra had claimed her as her daughter.

Fury and then terror.

And then something else.

A high pitched little mewl came from the would-be assassin's throat. And by some strange alchemy, the hurricane of teeth and claws collapsed into a *child.*

He very-much hoped the girl did not wake before Lyra got back.

Dr. Lenio's Bedroom,

Upper City,

Halfmoon.

Lenio was too stars-damned old to be woken by middle-of-the-night crises. But apparently the universe did not receive the memo.

"Dr. Lenio!" his housekeeper called through the door. "Come quickly! You have a… visitor."

"Well, tell them that unless someone's bleeding to death, they can wait a minute."

The door opened. A figure walked around the housekeeper into the room.

“Dr. Lenio? I'm sorry to wake you.” A familiar voice said, breathless and worried.

“Your Majesty?" Lenio had not had Queen Lyra show up at his home since he left the castle.

In the dim light from the hallway, her expression was stricken, ears back and her tail in her hand. “Arashu didn’t get close enough to find out if she was injured.”

Lenio sat up, grabbing his robe from the hook and shrugging into it. “Arashu?” What moron was allowing Arashu to treat an emergency? “What do you mean? Who is injured?”

Who would warrant Lyra coming all the way here herself at this hour, still dressed for the day? Lenio went over the short list in his head before Lyra's reply brought him up short.

“C’yara.”

The name hit like a hammer. No one had entertained the possibility of the Princess’s survival.

Light headed, Lenio put his feet on the cool wooden floor, concentrating on the sensation while he took in Lyra’s tear stained face.

“She's here?”

The Queen's scent was a complex mixture of distress as she nodded, grabbing his hand in both of hers and her eyes bright with tears.

“Gi… I mean… A sorcerer brought her back.”

She cleared her throat before she could go on, for once not hiding her grief or fear. “Dr. Lenio. Please. She’s sick. She’s hurt. Dr.

Arashu scared her so much that she drew claws on him. So he set the guard on her and she went on an absolute rampage."

She gasped as the words poured out of her.

“She passed out cold, and I took her to the infirmary, but I cannot think of anyone else I can trust,” she pleaded.

He nodded quickly, patting her hand.

“Tell me the rest as we walk. I’ll get my bag.”

Halfmoon Infirmary
Halfmoon Castle

Minutes later

In less than half an hour, footsteps alerted Akrash to the return of Queen Lyra.

And Lenio.

The man had not changed much. Perhaps his ears were a little grayer. He wore his nightclothes. Lyra must have dragged him from bed.

If Lenio’s household still ran the same way, a servant would be along soon with clothes for him.

“How is she?” Queen Lyra asked, striding to the girl’s bedside.

“Same as when you left, Majesty. Asleep,” Cloudfoot told her. He held up his hand to Lenio. “Be careful, she attacked Arashu.”

“Did she, now?” Lenio asked, sounding unconcerned, although he stood back from the bed and let the Queen go to her first.

Akrash stood up, intending to give them privacy. They did not need him here.

“Her Majesty said you brought her in?” Lenio asked Akrash, pinning him with a look before he could sneak out the door. “Do you know what spells were used on her?”

Akrash relaxed a little, although his heart hurt. Lenio didn’t recognize him. And why should he? Gone were Gideon’s gray stripes and green eyes. Even the shape of his face had changed.

Without looking at him, the other man took out the intricate indorium wire glove that he used as a magical focus and had turned toward his patient, wisely taking scans from a distance.

“Stasis spell. Also, look for lightning damage.” Akrash shuddered, thinking about what his sister had gone through before she had escaped the Horde. “Shadow Weaver hit her with some serious electricity and I don't think it was the first time. She's been drugged, and Shadow Weaver put her in stasis right afterwards. So, whatever they were, they're still in her system.”

Lenio’s head whipped around to stare at him and Akrash felt his stomach drop. Though Lenio’s eyes narrowed, he didn’t say anything, turning back almost immediately to the Queen.

“Can you wake her up? I don’t want to do anything until she understands that I’m trying to help,” he told Lyra. “And, if she can’t be roused, we have a different problem.”

Good idea. The girl had come up swinging when Arashu woke her.

Ariel still did that if you startled her awake.

The Queen spoke to the girl in a low voice, but she didn’t touch her. “C’yara? It's Momma.”

She sniffed hard, trying to keep the tears in. “Wake up, my heart. I won’t have you wake up alone again.”

“M-momma?” the girl gasped, snapping her eyes open. Her rounded pupils so large her irises were nothing but thin lines, she stared into Lyra’s eyes as though bewitched. One hand reached out to her face, stopping short of touching.

“Yes, C’yara.” The Queen’s voice thick with tears.

The girl stiffened, gold and blue eyes going flat and fearful as she drew back. Pupils contracted, but at least not the pinpricks of panic.

“Catra.”

“What?” the Queen asked softly.

“M’name’s Catra.” She pushed herself up on the bed, sitting up against the headboard, wrapping her arms and tail around her legs.

“Catra?” Lyra repeated slowly, tasting the name. “Is that what you prefer to be called?”

Fear spiked in Catra’s scent, but she nodded slowly, her chin raised like she expected a fight.

“Yes. Of course, Catra, then.” The Queen reached a hand towards the girl, but still did not touch her.

Confusion flashed across the girl’s face and Akrash thought of his own adopted mother's attempts to calm him when she rescued him from that ridge.

“I’ve brought a doctor to look at you.”

The girl mewled, young and scared, but then her jaw hardened. “Why?” Her voice a dry rasp.

“You’re sick. You’re hurt.”

“Your Majesty. Perhaps you should let Dr. Lenio work?” Cloudfoot asked, placing a hand on her shoulder. He was careful to not get too near the bed.

Lyra growled at her minister and shook his hand off. “I’m staying here with her. Have someone bring me bedding and night clothes. I will not have her frightened again.”

“Yes, of course.” Cloudfoot bowed, his face tight and his ears tilted back slightly, tension radiating from him in waves.

“Get out, Cloudfoot.” Lenio spoke almost absently. “Tell all those busybodies that the Queen will be here if they have business they feel they *must* attend to after midnight."

The minister looked between the Queen and the girl. Sighed. “Very well.”

Now that the girl was awake, Akrash edged toward the door. His heart pounded as he tried to slip out after Cloudfoot so he could process this somewhere quietly.

Lenio was *alive.*

The white furred stranger edged towards the door, trying (unsuccessfully) to make himself smaller and follow Cloudfoot out. Before he made it, Lenio said, “Not you. I have questions for you. Don’t leave.”

“Yes, sir,” a far-too-familiar voice muttered.

Lenio froze.

That voice… Like one he'd heard before. And his scent…

It could wait. This girl needed him first. The surface scans showed dehydration and malnourishment. The cocktail of incompletely metabolized drugs. Old and new spell damage that lurked under her skin.

She must have woken disoriented and in pain, her adrenaline in overdrive. Surrounded by strangers. Probably assuming she'd been taken prisoner. *Of course* she had run amok through the castle; she was a walking booby trap no-one had bothered to defuse.

"Why?" Catra asked.

"I called him, C'y… Catra." Lyra told her softly. "You're sick. You're hurt."

The girl shook her head. "M'fine." She was trembling, clearly at her last reserve, but he was not about to get into a power struggle with a patient. That led nowhere good.

"Catra, is it?"

The girl peered at him, nodding once, shrinking towards Lyra. That was something. If the girl trusted Lyra at all, they could probably get a sedative into her before he tried to do anything invasive.

"You ever seen a doctor before?"

Her eyes got big and her pupils contracted to slits. She nodded slowly and her black claws sank into the bed.

"Well, I'm Dr. Lenio. You're dehydrated and I want to get some fluids and medicine into you. Usually I'd do that by putting it directly into your veins with an I.V."

"Fuck that." The girl coiled like a spring, getting ready to jump up and fight. Her scent spiked with so much adrenaline that one

would think he'd just promised to cut off her fingers.

Lenio grabbed the exam chair, wheeling it back on its casters as he sat, giving her space. It'd been a while since he'd had to talk an enemy combatant into understanding he did not want to vivisect them.

If he had to, he would throw a sleep spell at her before she hurt herself, but that would probably make her even less trusting of them.

"All right. We can hold off on that for a minute." Lenio kept his voice even. "If you want, I've got a potion for you to drink that'll start healing some of that spell damage you've taken. It'll help with the pain you're in. Then we can do your I.V. and the rest when you're more comfortable."

"Potion?" She tilted her head and her eyes kept flicking toward Lyra.

"It's medicine. You drink it."

"What if I don't?"

"I'll wait until you pass out on your own." Lenio shrugged. "Not a problem for me. I've got all night. But then you'll be even worse off and you'll be sick longer."

Catra rubbed her hands together and flexed her claws as though they hurt. She looked at the Queen.

"Please, my heart," whispered Lyra.

The girl bit her lip. "What'll it do to me?"

"It will make anything we do hurt less."

Her red eyes and trembling hands betrayed how much her body wanted to sleep, but she held onto wakefulness with all her claws.

“And I can use numbing cream on your skin, if needles are a problem. I’ll be able to do the I.V. and take blood without it hurting so much.”

Lyra reached toward her. “I’ll stay right here. I won’t leave you.”

Lenio fiddled with his glove, just to have a reason to look away.

Something in the girl’s face softened and she leaned into Lyra’s hand. “Okay.”

“Here.” Before Lenio had even moved, the young man reached into the cold-storage cupboard where commonly used potions were kept. “Is this what you need?”

It was. Lenio used it a lot to calm scared patients; a mild sedative and magical restorative.

He cracked the seal and he held it out. Catra stared for a moment. Then her eyes went to Lyra who smiled gently and gave her a tiny nod.

A muscle in Catra’s jaw jumped and she squared her shoulders, taking the bottle and draining it. She wiped her mouth with the back of her hand as she handed it back.

No one spoke. Lyra’s tail lashed once as she studied the girl.

“Ooh.” The girl’s shoulders dropped slowly and her eyes sagged as it took effect. Her pupils rounded and her face softened. Now the lean into Lyra was obvious and the Queen moved around so that she could support Catra with one arm.

Without thinking, Lenio snapped his fingers at the young man, a well rehearsed gesture for his assistants to understand speed was vital.

“Catra, I need to put an I.V. in your arm to get those fluids in. Will you let me?” He was careful to keep his hands in sight.

Now she bit her lip, the soldier gone, leaving just a frightened girl. She pressed herself against the Queen and extended her arm

Not daring to break eye contact with the girl, now that he had gotten this far, he said, "I need…"

A packet hit his palm.

"Size twelve I.V. start," his assistant told him. Lenio glanced down; it was the right color package. "And the topical."

A fine tremor went through her arm as he shaved a small patch. He felt the resistance there as she forced herself not to pull away.

He smoothed on the topical anesthetic, keeping his movements slow, predictable.

"This will feel tight," he told her, tying the tourniquet on her upper arm.

Her claws flexed once against the bedding.

He felt a nice, easy-to-access vein on the inside of her elbow.

"Pinch." The topical should prevent that, but with a patient this wound up, it was better to err on caution. He pressed into the vein, and drew the needle back, leaving the catheter in place.

"Done."

She turned her head, staring at her arm as if expecting something worse to happen.

"That was easy," she muttered. Slowly the girl blinked, her focus softened.

By the time he secured the dressing, she'd gone limp with sleep in Lyra's lap. For a moment she looked so like the little lost Princess that Lenio's heart contracted.

Lyra stroked the girl's ears and purred.

He had not heard Lyra purr in *years*.

When he turned to ask for the next thing, the young man was already there, the line primed and waiting in his hand.

Lyra sat on the bed with the girl, while Lenio and the white furred stranger worked to address the immediate concerns.

Cloudfoot came and went a few times, bringing Lyra what she'd asked for and keeping her updated of the status of the casualties the girl created.

The sorcerer stayed and made himself useful, falling into the rhythm of caring for a patient with Lenio as if he had done it his whole life.

Finally, the girl was stabilized and Lyra had been installed on a bed next to her daughter. Lenio took a moment to set the monitoring spells that would wake him if Catra's condition deteriorated.

When he looked around, the young sorcerer was gone.

No matter. Cloudfoot would know where he was staying. Lenio needed a minute to sort through his thoughts.

The Queen believed Catra was the long-lost Princess. Her eyes and markings were exact.

But, as much as Lenio wanted it to be true, the Princess had shown robust magic. From his initial scans, Catra's magic was barely there—if it existed at all.

The DNA would settle it.

He grabbed his bag and headed to the on-call room. Four bunk beds lined one wall, with a small kitchenette tucked into the

corner. No one was there tonight; the worst injuries among the guards were fractures and lacerations.

His clothes hung in a cubby, but he climbed into a bunk, looking at the results of his scans on his tablet.

It took less than two minutes to fall asleep.

“I’ve arranged for a room in the castle for you, for tonight.”

Cloudfoot caught up with Akrash in the corridor.

“It’s just down the hall. Let me take you.”

Unexpected but it made sense if Lenio had questions for him.

Akrash had never had much use for hope, but he had chosen to believe Queen Lyra’s promise that she would not hold his parents against him. He didn't have any reason to refuse.

Chapter 2: Recognition

Chapter Summary

Lenio recognizes someone he has long missed.

Infirmary

Halfmoon Castle

Three days after Catra's abduction

Lyra refused to leave Catra's side for more than a few minutes. A line of visitors appeared at the royal infirmary door at stupid-o-clock in the morning, each expecting Lyra to carry on business-as-usual, but Lenio finally instructed the staff to tell everyone to message Lyra's tablet rather than clutter up the infirmary. The shadow outside the door of the office he appropriated could not be another useless Council member.

The white furred sorcerer stood hesitantly in the doorway. Much like someone else Lenio had known.

"I appreciate your help last night." Lenio turned his chair so he could face him. "The rest of these people are apparently scared of a teenage girl." He waved, dismissively indicating the rest of the infirmary.

An expression passed across the younger man's face. A pleased, almost shy smile.

Lenio *knew* that smile. Never mind that the shape of his eyes had changed, that the familiar stripes were gone and the lad's once-green eyes were the same blue Lenio saw whenever he looked in the mirror.

Was it possible? The young man's scent. The way he moved. His voice. They were *all* just like the boy Lenio knew.

He pushed his chair back and stared. “Gideon?” Lenio said it quietly, watching.

At the sound of the name, the young sorcerer froze, hand on the doorknob, hackles up, ears pinned, his scent spiking with anxiety.

Then he sagged, dropping his head and Lenio watched him gather himself the way he’d done when he was a boy and he knew Kellam or Varlaine were going to punish him. He picked up his head, squared his shoulders. Took a deep breath, pushing his emotions down, his face completely blank.

Lenio's heart skipped a beat.

This was the boy who’d wait outside his study door. Waiting to be invited in.

“Lad, don't lurk out there. Come in and shut the door.”

A fierce vertigo gripped Akrash, as though the floor dropped from under his feet, only his hand on the doorknob stopped him from flying apart.

Drawing in breath like he would before combat, he sagged for a moment, then straightened.

The words weren’t angry or accusing. Akrash did as he was told, his heart in his throat.

Lenio stared at him, eyes wide, pupils round, but otherwise his expression was the automatic “bedside” face all healers had. The one that hid their horror or fury.

“I thought you were dead.” The old man whispered as he stood. Took a step forward.

“Dr. Lenio… I’m sorry.” Akrash didn't move but gabbled out the first nonsense that came to his head. “I wasn’t trying to…” To what? He had been *very* clear with the Queen about who he used to be, but that hadn’t hurt like this.

No sigil appeared in the other man’s hands. Not that Akrash would have defended himself against Lenio.

“You disappeared.” The words choked and breathless.

“I'm sorry.” Akrash whispered, backing up until his back hit the wall. “They took me with them. I didn’t want to go.”

Tears threatened and he took a calming breath.

Lenio took another step and put his hands on Akrash’s shoulders, peering up at him, his eyes shiny. It was a surprise to be taller than the man. The last time Akrash saw him, Lenio still had a few inches on him.

“I know you didn’t,” the old doctor whispered, voice husky. “I chased Varlaine through half the city, trying to find you.”

“Kellam grabbed me.” Akrash couldn’t look away. The old man had looked for him? Gone up against Varlaine for him? “He was injured. Both of them were. They made me treat them.”

He *had* to tell Lenio this before he said any more. He had to get the worst out of the way.

“...I knew they were going to go up against the throne.” He sucked in a harsh breath. This was more than he admitted to the Queen. “I couldn't say anything.” He couldn’t look at Lenio, the man he'd wished countless times was his father. “They were planning for years.”

He closed his eyes and cringed away.

“They were going to apprentice me to Shadow Weaver.”

The grip on Akrash's shoulders tightened.

"Kellam… Put spells on me. Bindings." Akrash finally looked at Lenio as he waited for his fury. "I'm so sorry."

The old man's hackles were up and his ears pinned.

"You listen to me." Lenio hissed. "What those *mongrels* did to you was *never* your fault." He flexed his hands on Akrash's shoulders but no claws came out. "Not then and not now."

He leaned forward and pulled Akrash into a fierce hug.

It was like he was thirteen again, when Lenio would look for him and find him brooding in some secluded niche. A few words from his mentor and the tears would come. For a moment, he was concious of nothing else than the strong arms around him.

And just like he had then, Lenio led him to sit down on the couch in his office, an arm around his shoulder. "Come sit down, Gideon, before I make a bigger fool of myself." He sniffed and wiped his eyes, tactfully ignoring Akrash's tears.

"It's… um. It's Akrash," he said softly, his chest tight. "My… um… name." He perched on the edge of the couch, studying Lenio's face, gauging his reaction to the change. To all the changes.

"Akrash?" Lenio's eyebrows furrowed as he sat in the chair.

"My mentor called me that when she found me and I took it on." He looked away. "I didn't want anything to do with *them*."

Lenio's ears tilted back. "How long did it take you to get away*?"*

"A week? Maybe two. They left me when we reached the surface. My mm… My mentor found me then."

A tightness left Lenio's expression and his ears came forward.

“Akrash?” He spoke the name aloud slowly. Practicing it, settling it into his mind. “I like it. Suits you.” He tilted his head. “So, you’re a sorcerer now?”

A smile ghosted across Akrash's lips, because he always wanted to tell Lenio about it. “I trained in Mystacor. They trained me in healing *and* sorcery.”

“Mystacor?” The man grinned. “Mystacor!”

“My mentor is the Duchess.”

“Really?" Lenio's blue eyes shone with pride. "And Lyra said *you* brought Catra back from the Horde?”

“Yeah. The short version is that I heard the Horde had some magicats captive, but I only found one. Shadow Weaver let me have her in exchange for corrupting the Spirit Ember.” There was more to it, but Akrash knew Lenio was thinking about their patient.

“So, Lyra thinks that girl is her daughter. What do you think?”

Akrash shook his head, tapping the tabletop with a claw. “I don’t think she can be. Shadow Weaver told me she was, but I don’t know why she’d let me have her if that was true.”

“I’m having the lab do a genetic test.”

“Good idea.” Akrash replied. “There’s a lot of ways to make cosmetic changes.” He looked away. “Not too many sorcerers have discovered how to make those changes permanent, but Shadow Weaver probably could.” His tail flicked.

“Hm. What would it take to make those kind of changes permanent? I mean if it’s not her?”

A wince and a beat of silence. “Shadow Weaver would have had to use spells to rewrite her DNA instructions. She could dye fur

and even eye color with magic, but it wouldn't last more than a few weeks."

"So what…? In a few weeks the girl could revert?"

"Maybe. I don't know what she did to her."

"Would the tampering show up?"

"Oh, yes. The changes would not make her match Lyra's DNA. You can change the instructions that govern hair and eye color, but the rest of it would remain the same."

"That's reassuring that she couldn't fool a test." Lenio paused. "I cannot imagine how much that would hurt," he added quietly.

A shudder passed through Akrash and he winced again.

"Is that what happened to you?" Gentle now. The delicate tone of speaking to a shocky patient.

"Yes." Akrash looked down at his snow white claws.

Lenio's ears went back and his tail lashed so Akrash hurried to reassure him. "I chose this. I found Osirian spells in Mystacor's library." He flexed his claws. "I didn't want to look like *them* anymore."

"Why this?" Lenio gestured at him, his voice still soft.

"My mentor found me on a frozen ridge. She told her other apprentice I looked like a snow cat out of an old book. An akrash. I found pictures of them. They were gray as kittens and turned fully white as adults."

The reasoning felt almost too fanciful to share, but like Casta, Lenio had always encouraged his poetic streak.

"And… your eyes are blue," Akrash admitted.

A slow smile bloomed on Lenio’s face, wide and delighted despite the tear tracks on his cheeks. “Welcome home, Akrash.”

Chapter 3: Discoveries

Chapter Summary

Lenio discovers things he did not want to know.

Infirmary

Halfmoon Castle

Five days after Catra's abduction

Lenio watched the girl make fists and then stretch her hands out, unsheathing her claws. The same habitual gesture he'd noticed the first night.

He needed to look at them.

The last few days had been rough. When he ran titers he found that she had no vaccines other than her infant ones. Getting all those boosters at once was hard on her, but with Imoh preaching his garbage about vaccines being dangerous, there was a non-zero chance that Catra could catch something from one of the unvaccinated.

Lyra was out arguing with politicians who were annoyed that Lyra the mother was not nearly as reasonable as Lyra the Queen.

Leaving Catra to her own devices for too long was dangerous. She kept getting up and trying to exercise, even bound up to all the medical stuff. In her state she was a fall risk.

He refused to ask any of the infirmary staff to stay with her. Too many mutterings about her rampage through the castle and snide comments about her state when she was brought in. He never let on that he heard. Many of the youngsters thought he had to be half-deaf.

If he was still in charge of the infirmary he would have had some sharp words for them. He would certainly be having words about it with Lyra

“Dr. Lenio?”

Even with all of the worries this week had brought him, the sound of his boy's (yes, the boy was a grown man, but still) voice at the door made the old man grin.

“Akrash.” Dr. Lenio stood and hugged him. “Can you stay here with Catra? I’m going to go rescue Lyra from politics, and I don’t trust this lot not to lose their minds while I’m gone.”

He jerked his head at the door and made a noise in his throat. “I don’t know what they think she’s going to do. Just walking to the bathroom is a major feat right now.”

“How is she?” Akrash tilted his head at the observation window to her room. Since Lyra was gone, Lenio had opened the curtain.

The staff Catra took from Kittrina lay across her lap as she looked at the carvings on it. And she kept rubbing her hands like one of Lenio’s arthritic patients.

Her eyes flicked to the window and she snarled, baring her teeth as she felt them watching her.

“About how you would expect. Scared and confused. Doing an admirable job hiding it under layers of snark. She needs to eat more. Sleep more.” He smiled slightly. “She does remind me of Lyra as a teenager.” He sobered. “But she’s been through a lot.”

“Go in and talk to her. She’s really only seen Lyra and me. She needs some interaction and I'm afraid of what happens when soldiers get bored during their recovery.”

“Catra?” Akrash wasn’t sure at all how to approach her. She sat on her bed with a staff in her lap, looking at the intricate carvings. The I.V. set-up looked like a Plumarian holiday tree, festooned with bags of saline and medication.

Tense and wary, her hands tightened on the staff, ready to defend herself. He’d seen that in Ariel.

“You… “ Catra stared at him as though trying to remember something.

“Yeah. Me.” Cautious because he didn't know how she felt yet. Being away from the Horde would be an automatic improvement of her life, but she might not understand that yet. “I brought you here.”

She hissed at him.

It wasn’t personal (probably), so he ignored it. He remembered how he felt when Casta had taken him from that cliff. He’d been angry and scared too. It had taken a long time for his body to understand what safety felt like. He had hissed at people more than once those first few months in Mystacor.

“I'm called Akrash.”

“Catra,” she grunted, eyes following him, tracking his hands. Hands holding the staff loosely, at the ready. “So what are you doing here?”

“Hiding from the world.” He lowered his voice. “They seem to think I'm a responsible adult.” He added a performative shudder. “If I'm in here, they all assume Dr. Lenio or Her Majesty assigned me here, so they don't bother me.”

That *almost* got him a half smile.

“What is that?” he nodded with his chin at her staff.

“I won it in the fight,” she growled, pulling it towards her chest.

“You're good,” Akrash told her affably. “I hear the woman you beat is considered a very good fighter.”

Blinking rapidly at the compliment, she thrashed her tail, unsure. “They’re pissed at me because I scratched up their doctor,” she grumbled.

Akrash *tried* to tell Arashu what he was dealing with; that Catra had been tortured before she went into stasis. That she was a trained soldier. That he should give her something for pain and to calm her before bringing her out.

But the stupid man looked down his nose and said, “I hardly think I need advice from someone trained in *Etherian* healing. And I hardly think a sick teenage girl is that much of a threat.”

“He deserved what he got. I told him you were a soldier. Not my fault he’s an idiot.”

The corner of her mouth quirked up. For real, that time. “So… What? They sent you here to make sure I don’t run off to try to kill people?”

“You didn’t kill anyone.” Akrash asserted, his voice casual. “Which I appreciate. It would have been too much paperwork.”

Her shoulders dropped, as if relieved by his words. Interesting.

“Can I see that?” Nodding his head at the staff. When she hesitated he said, “I just want to look at the runes.”

She flipped it, bringing it to within an inch of his chin, but he didn’t flinch (Ariel played like this too). He merely took it by the end and held it away from himself so he could see the writing properly. “Oh, this is nice!”

“What’s that supposed to mean?” She yanked it back.

“That’s an old one. It was probably forged by a sorcerer smith. Channels magic.”

“Well, I don’t have any magic.”

Akrash shrugged. “If you don’t have much magic, it's still a good stick to hit people with.” He tilted his head. “I can tell you more if you let me look at it.”

“Get your own. This one’s mine.”

Infirmary

Halfmoon Castle

Seven days after Catra’s abduction

The DNA results were supposed to be ready today. Over the past week, Lenio had tried to prepare Lyra for the chance that Catra was not her daughter.

Lyra refused to consider that, saying that Catra had stood down when her magic had recognized Lyra’s own. Not an unreasonable thought, but it was also possible she was only seeing what she wanted to see.

Hopefully even if she weren't Lyra’s daughter, the girl's presence had at least broken open the box Lyra had been keeping her grief in for so long.

In the meantime Lenio applied himself to fixing the many problems the girl had.

The electrical damage was extensive and they were using some exotic potions to clean it up. He had done all of the non-invasive

imaging she'd allow.

Catra was terrified of needles. Terrified of most medical things. Her gaze went alarmingly far away whenever she had to have blood drawn. He'd ended up putting in a central line rather than repeatedly poking her. He had called in a couple of nurses that had worked for him before that he could trust. All had done stints as combat medics, so once he explained, they saw Catra as "traumatized" rather than "dangerous".

Another set of results came into Lenio's feed. He had done a full body scan of her systems and he was going over them with a fine tooth comb. The one currently on his screen was her nervous system.

That didn't look right.

He enlarged it. Was that… a lesion? On her brain?

He enlarged it again.

Oh.

That changed things.

These lesions were *old*. Calcified.

She shouldn't be alive.

The usual scans he did measured the passive magical energy that most people carried around normally. He had not thought to look for magic taken up with repairing her whole stars-damned nervous system.

A long, deep breath, as he composed himself. It was easy to miss, especially if one didn't know what a patient's baseline magic *should* look like. He needed to take another scan. One where he knew what he was looking for.

He knocked on the door, waited for her to call out, "Come in."

Catra watched him with narrow eyes. And she was doing that thing with her hands again.

He gave her a smile she did not return, and he went to check on the various medications on her I.V., removing the empty bags.

"I can take one of those out," he told her. They'd had to put two lines in her because of all the medications.

She shrank away, biting her lip. He waited for a hesitant nod before he approached her.

He removed the needle smoothly, soaking up the little bit of bleeding with gauze. Her eyes followed his hands and she kept flexing her claws.

"Do your hands hurt?" He had found that the direct approach worked best.

"They're fine." She lied.

"I'll be the judge of that," he growled.

She scoffed, and her ears came forward with the tiniest sign of a smirk, as though she thought he was ridiculous.

Well, fine. He'd take being scoffed at, if it gave him any way to connect with her.

She held out one hand palm down. Very gently he turned her hand, peering at the knuckles, carefully squeezing the bones and joints, watching for her wince.

He could see now. Fine scars at the base of her nails held cold heavy metal to her fingers. Her claws were black, as C'yara's had been, but they weren't *real* claws anymore. Sharper and harder than natural claws could ever be, they caught the light in harsh glints when they unsheathed.

“Did you know you had prosthetic claws?” The surprise leaked into his voice.

“Oh, no! Really?” She gasped sarcastically, pulling her hand back. “How did that happen? Imagine!” She rolled her eyes and her lip curled. “What, you think I’m stupid?”

He raised an eyebrow. “No, I think you are stubborn and irritable.”

And angry. And scared. And in more pain than she would admit.

“Yeah. Whatever,” she grumbled, crossing her arms. “Takes one to know one I guess.”

“Can I at least take a scan?”

“Fine.” Uncrossing her arms she extended her hands toward him and stretched them out.

For all that her agreement was reluctant, and her tone petulant, Lenio cheered internally. Three days ago, it had taken all Lyra’s power of persuasion to allow him to do anything.

He held his gloved index finger and thumb out in a “c” and looked at Catra’s outspread hands between them.

They had amputated the claws but not the claw sheaths? That did not seem possible, but the metal was perfectly integrated into her flesh and bone. Seamless and smooth.

He’d seen Catra flexing them. They functioned normally, so both the sheaths and the bone they attached to must have been regrown. The tendons gripped the metal as if it grew there.

Some *serious* magic had been used.

He tilted the scanner more generally toward her.

There.

He hadn’t been looking for this. Magic diverted. Consumed. Holding her together.

Now that he’d properly calibrated the scan, her whole body sparkled with copper colored magic. At least as strong as what one would expect from Lyra’s line.

All of it turned *inward.*

Those lesions represented what would have been a killing blow if she had not had magic. That could explain why Lyra lost the Princess’s magical track all those years ago.

If she *was* C’yara.

But Catra had magic C’yara never had. Nestled in her heart, a pool of warm golden Celestial magic. Bolstering her native magical healing.

His tablet pinged, and finished the scan. “Thank you.”

No answer; she’d fallen asleep. The fatigue was normal, even though she chafed against it.

Another ping, another result.

This one flagged in red.

DNA: 99.9% probability of relationship.

A match.

Her DNA matched Lyra’s.

The Queen had been right.

She *was* C’yara.

Lenio took a long breath, glancing at the sleeping Princess on the bed.

What had they *done t*o her?

He took his tablet and his unsteady emotions to his office and sat heavily at the desk.

After a few minutes, he felt equal to examining her other results.

The chart was a litany of abuse and neglect. He would need to be very careful about how he explained this to Lyra. There was *a lot* wrong with Catra and now that he looked at how her magic had to compensate, his blood ran cold.

But that made the prosthetics even more puzzling.

What had she said? All week she kept referring to herself as a failure. A reject. The Horde's big disappointment.

Kittrina was still telling everyone who'd listen that Catra *had* to be special forces. The guards complained about how she'd beaten them to a standstill.

She was a walking weapon and the Horde thought she was a *disappointment?*

Lenio knew that the Horde tended to send their expendable soldiers to Subtheria, but he knew that there couldn't be many soldiers of her skill level. Otherwise Etheria would have been conquered already.

He drummed his claws on the desk, feeling as though he were missing something.

They had gone to great lengths to steal her. A Princess from a Runestone-linked genetic line.

The lightning scars. Injuries, both old and recent. The amputations. Someone had tortured her to make her magic show

itself.

And that was probably the very reason they hadn't seen it. If she hadn't been fed properly. Given proper treatment. If she never had time to recover, it kept her magic occupied.

Survival came first.

Shadow Weaver… Akrash had confirmed she was not a healer. And she was Etherian trained. She would not have known to look for magic that had turned inward like this. To her eyes, absence was simply absence.

Her experiment was a failure. That was *why* the old witch gave her to Akrash.

The healed prosthetics and the Celestial magic remained mysteries, but he doubted Catra would know.

He sighed, and rubbed tired eyes before looking up the magical restoratives she'd need.

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